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Performing the future of work: Examining discourses of the future of work and the ideal worker through event ethnographies

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ABSTRACT

The future of work is a multifaceted subject, addressed in academic research, policy, and industry or business contexts. It is often depicted by different imaginaries about the potential impact of new technologies on work. In this paper, I argue that the portrayal of the ideal worker in future of work discourses continues to shift the burden of responding to an uncertain future of work onto the individual. I accomplish this by examining the discourse of the future of work and expertise performances through an event ethnography involving attendance at three major industry conferences, as well as through analyses of four Massive Open Online Courses (MOOCs) on the future of work. In the specific and localized character of the conferences and MOOCs, the idealized worker was framed as flexible, autonomous, resilient, emotionally intelligent, and proficient in using modern AI. These framings reinforce a narrow set of ideal worker norms, limiting which types of work and workers are seen as part of the future of work, and often shift the burden of adapting to structural challenges onto the workers themselves. Ultimately, I contend that researchers, policy makers, and industry must critically examine the discursive and spatial imaginaries shaping the future of work to better understand its uneven and unpredictable impacts across society. Overall, this research contributes to understanding the politics of the future of work, as well as the potential and limitations of researching events and online spaces within the context of economic and labour geographies.

1. Introduction

The "future of work" has generated extensive debate across academic research, corporate communications, and journalism. While work continues to evolve, its future remains uncertain. Recent books by authors such as Acemoglu and Johnson (2023), Benanav (2020), Brynjolfsson and McAfee (2014), Ford (2015), (Frey, 2019), MacLeavy and Pitts (2024), and Susskind (2020) represent some of the expanding and varied perspectives on the potential impacts of widespread technological innovation on employment. Geographers have contributed to future of work research by emphasizing its context-specific nature and overlapping scales of change between the local and global (Graham and Anwar, 2019; Gilbert, 2023; Islam, 2022; MacLeavy and Lapworth, 2020; Reid-Musson et al., 2020). In short, interest in technological change and its implications for employment is wide-ranging and productive of different research and imaginaries of the future of work.

This paper examines "the discursive politics of labour" within future of work imaginaries (Anant and Coe, 2021, p. 10), focusing on the political and performative representations of work and workers. I analyze two spaces in which the future of work discourse takes shape through performances of expertise: industry conferences and Massive Open Online Courses (MOOCs). These spaces are significant because they assemble different actors and performances that cultivate future of work imaginaries. First, industry conferences in this study are places where business professionals come together to discuss the future of work, listen and contribute to presentations and panels, procure expert knowledge, and build professional networks. Second, MOOCs analyzed in this paper present accessible and digitally mediated pedagogy that aims to explain the future of work to a wider audience from the course creators' perspectives – be they academic institutions, private companies, or international organizations. Both MOOCs and conferences are knowledge production sites. They serve as avenues for actors to perform expertise, cultivating, consuming, and legitimizing their interpretations of the future of work and imaginaries.

The paper begins with a research overview that situates contemporary conceptions of the future of work within and beyond geographical scholarship, laying the thematic groundwork for my analyses of the conferences and MOOCs. I then outline my methodological approach, drawing on participant observation and event ethnographies (Fairbairn, et al., 2022; Koch, 2023) to examine spaces in which future of work discourses are performed. Next, I present my analytical findings. Across both the conferences and MOOCs, I focus on idealized representations of the future of work and what kind of worker fits into these visions. Finally, I conclude with a discussion on limitations and suggestions for

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future research.

The future of work continues to be framed by a variety of actors and their projections of how work and workers will evolve, particularly around technology's potential to create social and economic disruption (Lynn et al., 2023). My approach contributes to ongoing discussions about the politics of working life and future of work geographies. This research adds nuance to future of work debates by scrutinizing its discursive politics and imaginaries. It also explores the potential of researching events, online spaces, and the importance of futures in the context of labour and economic geographies (Gong, 2024). I continue with dialogues about how geographers can examine the future of work, its broad and dynamic meaning, and how it is envisioned in different socioeconomic contexts.

2. What is the future of work discourse and why does it matter?

The future of work literature has frequently focused on technological changes that are reshaping production. For example, books on automation and its disruptive potential such as *The Second Machine Age* (Brynjolfsson & McAfee, 2014) or *A World Without Work* (Susskind, 2020) have become popular, especially as their narratives address a "perennial anxiety about automation" (Wajcman, 2017, p. 125). Economists continue to try and predict which jobs or tasks may be eliminated by new technologies, particularly via robotic automation or artificial intelligence (AI) (for notable examples, see Arntz et al., 2016; Frey and Osborne, 2017; Acemoglu and Restrepo, 2020). In addition to robots and AI, developments in blockchain technologies, genomics, 3D printing, and quantum computing have also shaped narratives about the future of work (Anthes, 2017; Clauson, 2020). In short, much of the future of work literature and cultural representation works toward forecasting technologies' impacts on employment, often even before these technologies are widely adopted by firms or the public. Even if such advances occur, technology adoption in workplaces is not guaranteed; predicting what new jobs might emerge alongside novel technologies that displace or transform existing work is difficult (Acemoglu and Restrepo, 2020). However, discussed below are examples of how geographers and other social scientists emphasize that changes to work driven by technology are not inevitable. Rather, this literature underscores the importance of understanding how future of work imaginaries are constructed and how our choices about technology's role in shaping work are socially influenced.

Economic and social theorist Benanav (2020) notably challenges the notion that automation is both inevitable and already a dominant force in the global economy. Instead, Benanav (2020) highlights that continued efforts to lower wages, shrink the labour force, and intensify work are more pressing concerns than widespread capital-intensive investments in automation. Likewise, economists Acemoglu and Johnson (2023) argue that key policy levers such as strengthening labour rights, regulating Big Tech firms (defined by large firms like Apple, Meta, or Google/Alphabet and their dominant market power), investing in education, and countering asymmetrical power over technology can redirect innovation toward prosperity. These debates remain dynamic, particularly within future of work policy spaces and public perceptions. For example, in a literature review by the International Labour Organization (ILO), researchers concluded that academic and grey literature on the future of work is polarized and often oscillates between optimism and pessimism (Balliester and Elsheikhi, 2018). Political economist Spencer (2019) contends that the oscillating narratives of fear and hope about new technologies obscure the crucial issue of ownership concentration in determining whether they will benefit or harm workers. In a future of work policy review, political scientists Schlogl et al. (2021) assessed explicit and implicit future of work assumptions. Policy solutions tended strongly towards upskilling or reskilling, regardless of sector or national context, with much of the responsibility for adapting to an uncertain future of work placed on workers themselves or educational institutions (Schlogl et al., 2021). Their analysis also revealed a "technologically deterministic" world of work in which a "rhetoric of inevitabilism" prevails that "sidelines human agency" in shaping which technologies will be adopted in different sectors (p. 17).

Like Schlogl et al. (2021), management researchers Dries et al. (2024) conducted an analysis of 485 print media articles and surveyed 570 technology sector experts, journalists, authors, policy makers, public administrators, and engaged citizens. They argued that three major competing future of work narratives prevailed: "Effective Accelerationism" (technocracy or optimistic technological growth), "Degrowth" (need for widespread system change), and "Capitalist Realism" (more regulation and policy fixes under the assumption that there is no alternative to capitalism). Dries et al. (2024) argued that to overcome deadlock in these competing narratives, we need to move away from trying to predict the future of work and instead focus on the imaginaries and futures of work we want to create in the present. Beyond future of work policy and written materials, Ćwikła and Lindell (2023) conducted a visual analysis of future of work imageries online, critically noting that they often depict young, happy workers in sterile office or home settings. Additionally, studies of popular culture and online future of work imagery reveal that robots, AI, and reimagined computing and machinery dominate visual representations (Czarniawska and Joerges, 2020). Visual representations and narratives of the future of work have the potential to exclude low-wage and older workers, while overlooking the realities of overlapping work and domestic environments.

Economic, social, and cultural geographers have also paid close attention to automation discourses both in workplaces and everyday life (Attoh et al., 2021; Lin et al., 2024). Samers (2021) examined grey literature and popular media discourse on the so-called "fourth industrial revolution" or "Industry 4.0", which he conceptualized as "futurological fodder". This "fodder" fed future of work narratives to produce differing imaginaries, including optimistic, pessimistic, and other integrative visions of human relationships with new technologies. Fraske (2022) noted that much of the Industry 4.0 literature does not incorporate economic geography, especially as spatial implications were rarely considered and when they were, space tended to function more as a container than a dynamic relation. Lazzeroni and Albanese (2023) analyzed how Industry 4.0 discourses have led to highly polarized perceptions regarding the future of work and new technologies in the public sphere. However, as Bissell (2023) has observed, new automation technologies and digital platforms, often touted as future of work cornerstones, continue to be unevenly deployed and often fail to live up to their vaunted potential. Likewise, Thomas et al. (2022) explained how places that have experienced industrial decline have significant emotional and cultural legacies that shape desires and orientations of the public toward new economic planning, initiatives, and projects, such as clean energy job creation or shifting to tourism industries. These orientations cultivate both disaffection and hope about the future as workers and consumers increasingly struggle to cope with the promises and perils of future of work imaginaries.

What is included or excluded in future of work narratives – particularly what counts as work, the expansion of precarious work, labour agency of workers, and perpetuation of social difference in the economy – continues to be a central theme in economic and labour geography (Coe and Jordhus-Lier, 2023; Raj-Reichert, 2022; Strauss, 2018; Werner et al., 2017). Feminist economic geographers have proposed a closer examination of what counts as work and which spaces are excluded in popular future of work narratives to challenge aspatial and technocentric readings (MacLeavy and Lapworth, 2020; Reid-Musson et al., 2020). Blackman et al. (2022) emphasized that care work tends to receive less attention in future of work debates despite being integral to global economies because it is often undervalued – disproportionately done by migrant labour from the Global South – and less likely to be automated. Similarly, Gilbert (2023) argued that research needs to move beyond factories and automation to consider other invisible labours, such as sex work which is increasingly mediated by digital platforms but

largely excluded from mainstream future of work theories. Islam (2022) argued that while remote work has become central to future of work discussions since COVID-19, especially for knowledge workers in the Global North, it is important to also consider unequal home-based work conditions, including disparities in space, internet access, and domestic responsibilities. Feminist economic geographers emphasize the interconnectedness of home and work as crucial for understanding the future of work's spatial extent beyond production spaces (Mullings, 2021; Winders and Smith, 2019).

Together these future of work framings are characterized by their multiple imaginaries and varying normative claims. Jasanoff's work has been essential in defining futures as "sociotechnical imaginaries" or the powerful discourses and fantasies of intertwined social and technological change. Jasanoff (2015) defines the sociotechnical imaginary as "collectively held, institutionally stabilized, and publicly performed visions of desirable futures animated by shared understandings of forms of social life and social order attainable through and supportive of, advances in science and technology" (p. 4). These visions are not apolitical but are shaped by power dynamics. As Hallin et al. (2025) argue, there is not one imaginary about the future of work but many co-existing and competing ones, which often posit different normative and political dimensions for acting in the present. While a range of scholars advocate for more nuanced and critical approaches to theorizing and debating the future of work, especially by centering workers' voices and rights, (Acemoglu and Johnson, 2023; Benanav, 2020; MacLeavy and Pitts, 2024; Lynn et al., 2023), examinations of popular media, policy, and grey literature often reveal imaginaries that perpetuate techno-optimistic or dystopian narratives rather than challenge prevailing assumptions (Czarniawska and Joerges, 2020; Dries et al., 2024; Samers, 2021; Schlogl et al., 2021).

Overall, researchers both within and outside of geography have drawn attention to the range of social, cultural, and material factors included or excluded from the future of work and how it is imagined. The discursive framing of work and workers is of continued interest to geographers. Such framings take shape in interesting was as envisioning the future of work influences how problems and solutions to work's changing nature are articulated by different actors. In the remainder of this paper, I unpack the discursive imaginaries of the future of work within corporate conferences and MOOCs I participated in and engaged with. While previous studies have focused on media, surveys, or reviews of academic and grey literature, I examined professionalized knowledge production spaces that communicate and represent the future of work.

3. Methods and methodological approach to events and discourse

Over 18 months (June 2023–December 2024), I conducted participant observation at three multi-day future of work conferences (two in Canada, one in the USA). I also participated in and completed four future of work MOOCs designed for global aspects and audiences. Descriptive characteristics are provided in Table 1.

Table 1
Descriptive characteristics of MOOCs and future of work conferences.

Type	URL	Summary
Conference	https://futureworkseries.com/canada	Annual conference on the future of work aimed at executives and managers in companies who hold a leadership position in Canada.
	https://futureworkseries.com/usa	Annual conference on the future of work aimed at executives and managers in companies who hold a leadership position in the USA.
	https://www.worktechevents.com/events/worktech23-toronto/	Annual conference specifically aimed at workplace technologies and changing work in Canada and Globally.
MOOC	https://futureofwork.fi/	Future of work survey course (now being updated as of 2025) created by Alto University in Finland.
	https://www.edx.org/course/working-remotely-and-covid-19	Course specifically focused on adapting to remote work since the onset of Covid-19 and its impact on working life.
	https://www.coursera.org/learn/designing-future-of-work#enroll	Future of work course focused on design principles created by the University of Northwest Sydney.
	https://www.edx.org/course/the-future-of-work-preparing-for-disruption-2	Future of work survey course focused created by the World Bank.

Inspired by recent methodological interventions on "event ethnographies" (Fairbairn et al., 2022; Koch, 2023), I examined how future of work imaginaries are performed in specific contexts. Events are temporally bounded encounters characterized by "unique space–time configurations" in which different "actors, imaginaries, and materialities" come together (Koch, 2023, p. 2). Although short-term, conferences and MOOCs are interesting sites because they generate space–time configurations for the conveyance of political or ideological orientations around societal problems (Brosius & Campbell, 2010). Craggs and Mahony (2014) argued that conferences create avenues for actors to "perform their legitimacy" as well as create an environment where attendance supports the "construction of expert identities – whether they are disciplinary, scientific, political or complicated hybrids" (p. 426). Put differently, performances that envision the future can legitimize certain frameworks and tools for imagining it, privileging some approaches over others. These dominant visions shape how people or institutions orient themselves and make decisions in response to anticipated or expected futures (Beckert, 2016).

In conferences and MOOCs, future of work imaginaries emerged through discussions that were largely channeled toward work arrangements, worker skills, and new technologies. I do not claim that these conferences and MOOCs offer a comprehensive account of the future of work beyond the geographical context of the US and Canada. Nor am I making specific claims about the impact or power that these event-spaces have on actual workplaces. My approach was exploratory, aimed at examining how the future of work discourses and performances manifest within the event-spaces of conferences and MOOCs. I did so by considering how future of work narratives are performed in concentrated spaces of knowledge production. Below, I detail data collection as context for the following analysis.

3.1. Data context: conferences

I selected conferences within the US and Canada because they are most geographically related to my broader research project on the future of work in Canada's technology sector. I selected conferences with descriptions or promotional materials that implied imparting knowledge about or preparing for the future of work. I examined preliminary programs, keynote speakers, and corporate sponsors to identify conferences that focused on the future of work in general rather than those that were tailored to the perspective of a specific industry

I attended three future of work conferences between 2023 and 2024 (Table 1). Two were held in Toronto, Ontario, and one in Chicago, Illinois. These conferences, aimed at businesses and their employees, were expensive; basic entry level admission prices ranged from $700 to $850 CAD with options to spend significantly more for corporate team packages or access to exclusive content and side events. Promotional materials and conference websites indicated and that these conferences were tailored to corporate audiences, primarily executives and employees with the budget to participate, rather than to the general public. Most speakers at the conferences were not academic researchers, but were typically business leaders and consultants. In contrast to the relatively inexpensive and accessible MOOCs, the conference cost and marketing suggested an intent to curate exclusivity, prestige, and access. Conferences were intensive and immersive, starting early in the morning and running into the evening, including social or networking events. My attendance led to my e-mail being distributed to a broader network of attendees, organizers, and corporate sponsors. This resulted in hundreds of emails pitching future of work products or services. It also led to invites to numerous free webinars or workshops, some of which I attended to further immerse myself in my research object: expertise performance and the business of selling solutions to future of work challenges. In sum, the conferences were rich events with significant amounts of detail and discussion around the future of work.

3.2. Data context: MOOCs

I applied a similar selection criterion for MOOCs, focusing on those that offered explanations of the future of work and how to prepare for it. I participated in four MOOCs (Table 1) that explicitly addressed the future of work. MOOCs are online courses generally characterized by their scalability and potential to reach thousands of participants via automated teaching methods and predesigned content. MOOCs generally require little or no supervision or instructor interaction and are designed to be completed asynchronously at students' own pace (Robinson et al., 2015). Many MOOCs are free, may cost less than similar university courses (depending on national education costs), or are offered via subscription services from platforms such as edX or Coursera. In some cases, MOOCs are part of a broader course offering to gain a credential

MOOC structure, instructional oversight and engagement, design, and administration varies. Many universities offer MOOCs, as do institutions such as The World Bank or large multinational companies such as IBM. In selecting courses for this research, I reviewed major digital platforms that provide MOOCs (e.g., *EdX*, *Coursera*, *Udemy*) and conducted simple web searches (via Google). I examined course descriptions to prioritize courses that claimed to provide knowledge about how to understand and prepare for potential workplace changes. I sought courses that were framed as expert future of work accounts with a general audience in mind. Although many MOOCs were available, I excluded those with irrelevant content and those lacking major company or university affiliation.

Beyond critical review and examination of course material, I also engaged with courses as other students would: I completed readings, assessments, and assignments. I studied course content carefully as both a student and a researcher, completing each MOOC one at a time. Each MOOC had a particular thematic future of work focus, for example, The World Bank course focused on global development indicators while a course from the University of Sydney focused on firm-level workplace design and decision-making. The MOOCs drew on a mix of sources, primarily grey literature, online news media articles, blog posts, and other popular media, alongside public lectures by academics, business leaders, and entrepreneurs, and, to a lesser extent, peer-reviewed research and university-level textbooks.

3.3. Data collection and analysis of discourse and performances

Data collection consisted of two core elements: (1) detailed experiential field notes and (2) digital materials from conferences and MOOCs. For the conferences, I recorded field notes on paper on site and later transcribed to a digital format. I reviewed PowerPoint slide files from speakers or panelists and/or other digital promotional materials that were provided to attendees. MOOC field notes were digital; I recorded reflections as I worked through course content. In some cases, I took screenshots or saved various course materials, like assignments and assigned readings, to document important context. I constructed a summary reflection of each conference and MOOC to capture my overall impressions, themes, and personal affective resonances to determine how each event did or did not provide interesting research insights.

I coded field notes, reflections, and other materials (such as screenshots, PowerPoint Slides, illustrations described above) using NVivo. My first coding round was based solely on identifying general themes, categories, or patterns (Cope, 2017). PowerPoint slide decks and conference materials often represented key analysis objects and helped my personal conference experience recall. Field notes and reflections were crucial in capturing my "critical acts of sensemaking and interpretation" (Eriksson et al., 2012, p. 9) and shaping my understanding of the future of work as an emergent discourse in these spaces. After initial coding, I reviewed themes and categories to identify more concrete coherences and incoherences, often developing additional codes. Overall, 11 major thematic clusters emerged: worker agency; AI impacts; COVID-19; social difference; emotions and wellbeing; employer/workers power dynamics; future of work framing; hybrid work; remote work; skills; workplace culture. Across these codes, different sub-codes further refined the content within a major theme. Table 2 outlines major thematic codes, sub-codes, and overall frequency of coded content

In analyzing conferences and MOOCs, I observed different visions and interpretations of the future of work. I examined discourse as a practice and I focused on who was speaking, why, and what knowledge was being generated in these spaces (Foucault, 1971, 1990). Prior future of work literature provided an initial thematic foundation for data collection and analysis. For example, I carefully observed the technologies described and types of workers represented in the conferences and MOOCs. Discourse, being more than merely words, is also performed through "epistemic objects" (Anderson, 2010) used to present the future, such as trends, statistics, stories, anecdotes, reports, images, and affects, such as fear, hope, and anxiety. Both the conferences and MOOCs were full of such objects; conferences had affective resonances with anticipation and preparing for the future of work. Like Bissell's (2021) work on "encountering automation," my approach focused on the future of work as a shifting object of study, especially through expertise performances.

By performative I specifically mean that language shapes the world rather than merely describing it (Butler, 2010; Gregson and Rose, 2000). Such performances can shape how the future of work is understood and experienced as a discourse while also extending legitimacy of future of work experts. Following Thurlow and Jaworski, 2017, I view this set of future of work conferences and MOOCs as producing elite discourses where elitism or being an 'expert' is a practice performed and communicated in a specific context, not an innate identity. Both conferences and MOOCs served as spaces for staging or platforming expert 'analyses' and 'opinions' framed as opportunities to share or gain privileged knowledge and experience on the topic. My focus was on how expertise

Table 2
Thematic codes clusters, sub-codes, and frequencies.

CODE CLUSTER (N)	SUB-CODES (N)
Worker Agency (29)	
	Adaptable and/or resilient (10)
	Creative (9)
	Describing worker agency (14)
	Self-skilling (8)
AI Impacts (34)	
	AI inevitability (17)
	AI job creation, elimination, or transformation (16)
	AI skills (18)
	AI Critiques (3)
COVID-19 (13)	
Social Difference (24)	
	DEI content (12)
	Generational conflicts (6)
	Women and gender (6)
Emotions and wellbeing (61)	
	Care and self-care (4)
	Emotional skills (29)
	Emotional wellbeing and productivity (21)
	Empathy (9)
	Work-life recognition (13)
Employer/worker power dynamics (27)	
Future of work framing (50)	
	Changing meaning of work (21)
	Futuring as a practice (17)
	Measurement and prediction (9)
	Technological imaginaries (7)
Hybrid work (30)	
	Negative perceptions (3)
	Positive perceptions (27)
Remote work (39)	
	Negative perceptions (21)
	Positive perceptions (15)
	Quiet quitting (3)
Skills (31)	
	Creative skills (2)
	Emotional skills (9)
	Self-skilling (10)
	Technical skills (10)
	Upskilling (8)
Workplace culture (18)	

was performed through authoritative accounts of what the future of work entailed, its key challenges, and proposed solutions. It is important to note that these performances and discursive framings are inherently unstable, transient, and may not always be cohesive or powerful. Nevertheless, they possess the potential to create a "performative force" or the power to shape meaning through performative acts (Glass and Rose-Redwood, 2014, p. 2). Accordingly, my analysis was not focused on whether conferences or MOOCs accurately represented the 'reality' of the future of work or aligned with academic research. Instead, I examined how these understandings were constructed through language and performances. Put another way, the aim of considering and analysing discourse at events was to consider the "operation of these constructive processes" of future of work imaginaries (Potter and Wetherell, 1994, p. 48).

In the proceeding analysis, I examine how conferences and MOOCs contained performances of expertise that produced specific imaginaries of the future of work. I present key thematic narratives that emerged, focusing on salient moments that relate to work, workers, and workplaces and how they are defined in the future of work discourse of the conferences and MOOCs. As idealized work and worker subjects stood out as prominent across the thematic clusters and sub-codes in my data, I spend time on these concepts specifically.

4. Results and discussion: future of work discourse and the ideal worker

The conferences and MOOCs offered different but overlapping spaces representing various discursive imaginaries of the future of work. The conferences, for example, included social interactions between participants and organizers while the MOOCs were more isolated experiences. My analysis focused on: (1) how future of work discourses were constructed through ideas, language, and practices that shaped the "discursive politics of labour" (Anant and Coe, 2021, p. 10); and (2) the dominant imaginaries produced through performances of expertise. Discourse and imaginaries are useful here in that they emphasize how language, actions, and performances materialize visions of the future (Jasanoff, 2015). This analysis focuses on how workers are represented within future of work imaginaries of the conferences and MOOCs.

The meaning of the future of work was contested and differed between conferences and MOOCs. However, in each context, I discerned a series of representations of 'the ideal worker'—the privileged subject of the future of work—discussions of which form central theme for this analysis. The discourse increasingly framed workers as responsible for their future; one MOOC emphasized that preparing for the future of work means workers must begin to "[locate] themselves in the future" and be an "agent of your own future". The ideal worker was consistently described as flexible, autonomous, resilient, emotionally intelligent, and competent with modern AI tools. These framings reinforce and extend problematic ideal worker norms. They do so by focusing almost exclusively on knowledge workers and placing the burden of adapting to structural circumstances onto individuals.

I focus on the workers as *ideal subjects* to capture the nuance of the future of work both in academic literature and elsewhere. I do so especially to avoid framings that confine future of work imaginaries to economic dystopia or techno-optimistic utopia. Instead, I highlight instability and malleability. I discuss the ideal future worker through three core imaginaries: (1) new hybrid work modes; (2) emotional skills and resilience; and (3) AI's role in enhancing worker capacities. I conclude by arguing for a shift towards thinking about the futurity of work

4.1. The ideal worker and hybrid work

Data analysis revealed clear tensions around the spatial organization of work. This was almost exclusively framed around white-collar work and the office or home as primary sites of productivity. These discussions were frequently centered on debates about remote work and the shift toward "returning to the office" or getting "back to normal" following COVID-19 stay-at-home protocols. Given monumental remote work impacts on workplace geographies during the COVID-19 pandemic (Reuschke and Felstead, 2020), I anticipated that remote work narratives would be significant within future of work discourses. As data

collection began in June 2023, COVID-19 work-from-home regulations had largely ended in the USA and Canada and debates about returning to the office were growing (Gibson et al., 2023). Still, various companies continued regular or even permanent remote work and people continued making significant adjustments to their working lives at home (Cockayne, 2021; Orman et al., 2023).

I focus on the conferences in this section, as many presentations and panels spoke about remote work's merits and hybrid returns to the office. Hybrid work refers to arrangements where workers are expected to balance their working hours between an office location and other locations, usually at home (Bloom et al., 2024). The most popular sessions I attended were on these themes, consistently filling conference spaces. I saw a clear trend emerge in which presenters, such as CEOs, executives, managers, and management consultants, framed a hybrid workforce as the most ideal future, including debate about how best to implement optimal working location ratios

Many presenters and panellists justified the desirability of hybrid work by arguing that remote work arrangements contribute to a growing "lack of connection" among employees. It was emphasized that some in-person work is required for business success. As a human resources (HR) management consultancy CEO put it to the audience: "connection benefits the bottom line" and remote work has "created a downswing in employee engagement". In turn, expert presenters repeatedly touted hybrid work arrangements as "the best of both worlds" – referring to having both access to some remote work and mandatory office use. The shift toward hybrid work was often presented as a default assumption about spatial organization of future workplaces. In an advertising agency presentation, a single slide with no other text spelled this out, stating "hybrid work is the preferred choice and dominant way of working".

Because hybrid work was framed as a logical shift, a frequent discussion point was how it could be used to resolve workplace tensions. Conference presentations centered different "solutions" to "problems" employers might have implementing hybrid work. In an HR executive's presentation, titled "Solving the Hybrid Conundrum", remote and hybrid work were presented as opposites. The presenter, a top HR executive at a global digital marketing firm, asserted that "people can be productive at home and appreciate wellness benefits, however connection to culture, collaboration and engagement are at risk" – referring to the need for in-person work to drive workplace culture. In the same presentation, the presenter adopted a pejorative tone towards workers who resisted or did not want to adopt a hybrid model, stating, "if you want to sit in your PJs at home, I can't help you". This statement was suggestive of a prevalent laziness among fully remote workers. Later that same day, a similar presentation was given by a communications executive at a software development firm titled "Human Connection in the Hybrid World of Work." A single slide with bold white font posed the question, "Your workplace is now a battle zone for attention – what do you do?" – suggesting combat between employers and workers. Across the conferences, it was clear that the transition to hybrid work and return to office was affirmed by employers – albeit often with the careful framing that this was a neutral or natural and logical choice. Likewise, these narratives often framed workers as inherently resistant to hybrid work over fully remote work.

Conference participants also produced discourses about the future of work, office returns, and viewpoints on colleagues' work commitments. In the registration line at one conference, two women were discussing remote work and how their employers were dealing with the fact that "nobody wants to come back to work". Similarly, during a coffee break at one conference, a senior executive from a major credit card company told me he felt that COVID-19 had "changed people" as he pointed at his head, spinning his finger, which I interpreted as as implying mental instability. He went on to further express annoyance at his executive-level colleagues who did not want to return to the office. Conference discussions tended to centre a need to get "back to normal" – which usually meant a return to the office alongside some remote work continuation. A common phrase espoused by panellists, speakers, and other conference participants was the idea that the "pandemic opened the door" to remote work and it would be difficult to eliminate it entirely. As one CEO presenter put it, "Covid erased certain geographic barriers" and "shifted the social contract" of work. This framing of the social contract portrayed employer and employee dynamics as if they were a neutral and mutually agreed upon set of circumstances, rather than contested and shaped by the differentiated nature of power in these relationships.

Hybrid work was further justified by framing workers' behaviours in workplaces. For example, presenters used differences in employee roles to generalize preferences for remote versus in-person work. One large insurance company executive on a panel said, "marketing loves to be in person; software engineers, not so much". Similarly, one HR professional emphasized that "there's a cost with coming into the office… not just monetary, but also to well-being". They went on to describe challenges of maximizing employee happiness – thus increasing productivity – against stress from commuting to the office. Panelists and presenters from various firms consistently highlighted trade-offs between fully remote and in-office work, favoring hybrid work, suggesting that it mitigates remote work's perceived negative impact on productivity and workplace culture. For instance, a large IT firm representative argued that "hybrid work provides a unique opportunity to gain better visibility into space utilization, and apply those insights to support a safer more efficient, cost-effective environment". Despite ongoing tensions and employee preferences for fully remote work, experts consistently framed hybrid work as the optimal solution.

Experts justified the shift to hybrid work, describing a future where the office and home are both productive spaces used to maintain workplace culture and are overlapping sites of waged labour. This framing portrayed workers as needing to be adaptable to changing hybrid work arrangements and new expectations of working remotely and in-office. These moments show that despite different preferences for work location, there are emerging tensions around autonomy and control that employers and employees have over when and why work needs to take place in an office location (Cockayne and Treleaven, 2023). Likewise, the hybrid work discourse I witnessed reinscribed workplaces as spaces for investment and maintenance of attachments to workplace culture, especially for connection, passion, love for work, personal satisfaction, and career development (Cockayne, 2016; Secor et al., 2024).

Increased desires for hybrid work extends views of workplaces as active spaces for the social construction of work and worker subjectivities (Weeks, 2011). McDowell (2017) has described the normative 'ideal worker' is segmented, often framed as "intelligent, well educated, mobile and adaptive, able to sell himself," and thus predicated on an othering of gendered and racialized workers outside the knowledge economy, in public and service sectors (p. 81). This continues to be consequential as remote, or hybrid, work is typically only available to a small minority of workers; there is a risk of over-stating their significance in the future of work (McCollum, 2025). Other scholars have noted how norms around who is a 'ideal worker' are changing. For Neely (2020), workers are increasingly atomised and must brand themselves by creating a portfolio of skills and social networks. Howcroft et al. (2024) noted that as workers engage in both remote and in-office work, the ideal worker is now marked by both physical presenteeism in-office and the always-on digital connectivity of remote work. The implication of hybrid work is that work is less about fixed spatial demarcations and more about "spaces of coordination that can adjust the definition of purposeful activity" as workers oscillate between the office and home (Richardson, 2021, p. 359). By framing hybrid work as the ideal spatial configuration of knowledge or white-collar work, the ideal worker flexibly and effortlessly balances work-life across time and space, contributing to meaning, connection, workplace culture, and productivity.

To summarize, across event-spaces there was a strong focus on

hybrid work, creating a dominant imaginary of flexible hybrid work in the future. It became a default position or expectation that the ideal future worker is spatially hybrid. I next pick up on this hybrid backdrop and discuss how the ideal worker took shape, intersecting with both social and technological future of work framings.

4.2. The ideal worker: increasing emotional skillsets and resiliency

Discussions about the future of work frequently centred on how workers should respond to rapid and uncertain labour market change. For instance, in one MOOC's introductory material, the future of work was framed by stating that "work has always been changing" and what is different is the "pace" of change. Another MOOC described job change intensification, stating that workers "are changing jobs more than ever" and that there has been a "230 % increase in frontline workers having changed 2+ jobs in a 6-month period over the last 5 years". Conferences and MOOCs often described how to manage changes impacting the labour force. A workplace culture consultant opened a conference welcoming speech with the rhetorical question: "What is the future of work?" They summarized it succinctly with three words: "Adaptive, unique, empathetic." Work-life balance, wellbeing, and emotions were often invoked. Here I explore how the ideal worker was framed as resilient to change and emotionally adept at responding to an uncertain work future.

Based on existing future of work literature, I expected conversations about desirable skills and worker personalities to be present in both the conferences and MOOCs. However, skill discourse was complex and multifaceted. One conference panelist specified that "worker agency and autonomy" are key for a "happy workforce", especially when workers are empowered to choose which skills to develop rather than being required to undergo mandatory training. Similarly, the CEO of a communication firm delivered a conference's opening remarks, stating that workers should not just be broken down into overhead costs or viewed as order takers but rather defined by their agency. In one MOOC it was emphasized that "humans are not powerless to intervene" and have agency in shaping the future. These expert framings of agency, as a quality that employers can leverage, complicate labour geography's ongoing efforts to expand the conceptual power of agency through acts of resistance, re-working, or resiliency (Coe and Jordhus-Lier, 2023; Strauss, 2020). At conferences especially, worker agency was individualized largely through a productivist framing. This opens new tensions between how employers might cultivate a sense of autonomy and agency within workers that contrasts how geographers position agency as a means of exploring workers as active agents in informing and changing their working spaces and conditions against capital's hegemony.

Skills and agency in responding to change were especially defined by content speaking to workers' capacities for managing work stress. One MOOC defined "emotional intelligence, psychological resilience, the ability to set boundaries, and self-care or wellbeing" among the most important skills needed to navigate expected labour market and global economy turbulence in years to come. Another MOOC explicitly stated: "Abilities such as grit have economic returns that are often as large as those associated with cognitive skills". Stress and wellbeing were also common topics, although approaches at times seemed questionable. One MOOC argued that from a "physiological perspective, stress is not intrinsically negative", "demanding situations are a key element of growth", and workers need to optimize their stress more systematically by ensuring rest and breaks during the workday. The same course described the "best advice" for workers to "adapt to an uncertain future of work" was to be self-reflective and proactively consider how some of their work activities might be jeopardized by automation – holding space for anticipatory automation anxiety. In this framework, adapting to the future becomes a skill in and of itself through self-optimization and creating a sense of security or denial of precarious conditions' existence (Ettlinger, 2007).

One reductive representation of emotions stood out to me during a conference presentation on employee engagement. An HR executive from a private sector social services firm gave a presentation that used a metaphor of fruit to represent workers' emotional states. A strawberry represented a worker with external anger – indicated by its red color—while a watermelon—with a red inside and green exterior—indicated hidden anger or dissatisfaction with working life. A leader's goal, according to the presenter, was to turn employees into green fruit, like grapes – happy and emotionally satisfied, inside and out. At one point in the presentation, fruit was literally cut on stage and the presenter jested, "get rid of those red strawberries," which, attempting to interpret how this metaphor related to a real-world circumstance, I took to mean constructive dismissal or perhaps progressive disciplinary action. Although I found this metaphor disturbing, the audience generally seemed appreciative; it was frequently revisited in later conference sessions, lunch breaks, or Q&A sessions. Likewise, during my time in group discussions and interacting with other attendees, several individuals described this as their favorite conference presentation or as a moment that stood out to them.

During another presentation, a particular emotional outburst struck me. In discussing the future of work, the presenter – a consulting firm CEO – was overcome with emotion. He shed tears as he stated 97 % of his employees described their workplace as "great" in an internal survey. Some in the audience – to my surprise – seemed to follow the moment and its affective resonances by making audible sounds of awe, even clapping or cheering for his emotional display. Whether in this CEO's display or the metaphorical elimination of "strawberry workers", emotions had a perceived value and utility in the workplace and uncertain future of work response.

Across conferences and MOOCs, emotional wellbeing came up repeatedly. In some cases, presenters cited statistics – without sources or citations – such as "43 % of employees have issues with feeling ignored and invisible," or "60 % of people are emotionally detached from their work," and "19 % are miserable". These were frequently used to highlight wellbeing issues. As one MOOC described, "emotional agility and resilience" were skills urgently necessary for workers to adapt to unpredictable, changing work environments and cultures. This was frequently framed as an upskilling task via workplaces encouraging the implementation of "invest in yourself days" where workers take time off to create and manage their own self-care practices or learn new skills outside the workplace. This is significant because some research suggests workplace wellness initiatives may have limited or no effectiveness in improving workers health and wellbeing (Fleming, 2024; Song and Baicker, 2019).

The emotion and agency discourse framed the ideal worker as both "emotionally intelligent" and having "grit" to adapt and overcome change. Cultivating the right emotions while simultaneously repressing bad emotions in the future of work discourse represented a tangible shift to acknowledging emotion's role in productivity and worker well-being (Webster and Trista Lin, 2025). While it was surprising to see the extent to which emotions were discussed, they were described in an essentialist way to serve productivity rather than as fluid and relational (Ettlinger, 2004).

4.3. The ideal worker and AI

Discussions on how AI will transform work, and how workers should respond, were central themes across the conferences and MOOCs. While discussing the pace of technological change and how to be future-ready, an HR executive from an insurance firm said we "cannot keep up with the pace of change if we're always asking for permission" – referencing the introduction of new workplace tools or processes. This moment reflects a broader narrative surrounding "Big Tech" and its pervasive "move fast and break things" culture (Laurent and Glăveanu, 2023). At the time of these conferences, AI was dominating the news with the rise of large-scale language learning models such as ChatGPT. At one

conference, a keynote speaker from a management consultancy opened by declaring that AI was now a more pressing and influential trend than remote or hybrid work. Later at the same conference, a chief innovation officer presented a survey showing that 14 % of US CEOs believed their company would see a reduction in staff due to AI. The attitude that AI was one of the most important work issues in the world continued throughout the conferences. At another conference, an HR executive from a software development firm stated (without a citation) that 87 % of companies are actively testing AI to help with hiring processes. At another conference, a director from a management consultancy claimed that every company should have an "AI task force" – if they did not, they were certainly behind the times. Overall, AI was positioned as the most prominent and consequential technology discussed within the conferences and MOOCs.

Despite the emphasis on AI, there was also at times a tempering of its impact on work. In general, there was optimism that AI would improve jobs rather than eliminate them entirely. As one presenter representing a software firm developing their own AI tools said, the goal was having AI "enhance human touch points". Companies like Microsoft and Google held workshops that were essentially sales demonstrations of their AI products – rather than preaching worker elimination, these demonstrations were geared toward reducing time to task completion and streamlining business processes. This point was reinforced by a communications specialist during a panel presentation, who noted that while AI may be capable of handling certain routine organizational communications, it cannot fully replace human interaction. This panellist emphasized that: "human touch will never go away". During a small group discussion with fellow attendees, all found it hard to believe that AI could completely replace their work. Most in the small group acknowledged that AI was "already here and changing work," although most presentations typically discussed it in abstract terms rather than demonstrating its practical use. AI's impact remained in vague hypothetical scenarios or a general interest in how it could be used going forward.

After attending one conference, I was invited to a subsequent invite-only workshop designed to train attendees on how to "optimize their time with AI". Compelled to dive deeper into AI in future of work discourse, I accepted. At the workshop, generative AI examples were presented in addition to a walkthrough on "prompt engineering" – how to structure and ask generative AI chatbots like ChatGPT better questions to obtain better results or outputs. This included 'automating automation' or running multiple, repetitive strings of AI prompts, such as scouring the internet for new sources on the same topic each day or having a generative AI analyse your weekly tasks and calendar to create an optimized to-do-list. From the workshop's start, the instructor – who described themselves as an "AI operations expert before it was cool" – warned that "you won't be replaced by AI, but you will be replaced by someone who uses it better" (see Blackman and Cockayne, 2025). As such, prompt engineering was framed as a way to "gain more time" by not necessarily reducing work hours, but by making space for increasing the value of non-AI tasks, like critical thinking, problem solving, and so on. This was described as "working AI-first" or prioritizing a "personal AI-system" to maximize our own optimization. This illustrates the tension between the optimistic promise of AI in the workplace and its potential risks. I viewed these as performances that sought to legitimate AI's use to get ahead in the labour market or at work and to prepare for the future rather than to lighten the amount of work overall (see Spencer, 2025).

In outlaying AI geographies, Walker and Winders (2024) argued that it remains to be seen "how the specificities of place—infrastructures, work cultures, labour histories, global connections, and so on—will shape the ways that AI affects labour and that workers respond to, appropriate, and resist those impacts" (p. 229). Across the conferences and MOOCs, AI inhabited a sense of inevitability in its adoption and expectation that workers will need to be skilled up in using AI across a variety of contexts. At the same time, how AI might replace workers loomed large – as one MOOC's content noted, "algorithms do not need to eat". Several conference presenters suggested we start thinking of generative AI chatbots as workers themselves or part of the labour force. This further complicates AI's role, not just as a tool, but as a political entity that encodes viewpoints, biases, and exclusions through opaque, unaccountable, and difficult to govern knowledge production processes (Amoore et al., 2024). Whether AI is framed as a tool that workers must adopt or as a functional replacement to human labour, new ethical challenges abound.

AI narratives tended to speak of AI as inevitable, reflecting what Cheney-Lippold (2024) calls the "temporal paternalism" of Big Tech (p. 2). Expert rhetoric often positioned AI as if the future had already arrived, producing a vision of the future with the potential to exclude certain groups from shaping or participating in these debates. McLean (2024) argues that it is necessary to avoid getting swept up into AI doomsaying – especially if it obscures more immediate ethical and social challenges. Instead, turning to feminist theorizations of care and repair may be necessary to address situated instances of AI use at work, mitigating harm and pushing back against the inevitability framing (McLean, 2024). Critical orientations will be needed as the ideal future worker is now inherently bound up in AI discourse and the future of work simultaneously.

4.4. *The futurity of work and what's next*

In a panel discussion with several HR executives and CEOs discussing the labour market, one panelist summarized recent trends: "2022 and 2023 was a focus on retention and labour force issues; 2024 is now a focus on fiscal pressure", referring to potential layoffs or organizations restructuring. Later, the moderator asked, "Has the power dynamic flipped?" in terms of providing remote work and flexibility. The same panelist spoke up energetically and said, "it's flipped back to the employer!". He qualified his statement by saying that he did not like the "power framing" and that instead "it's not about power, it's about relationships". This moment encapsulates the broader atmosphere of the conferences and MOOCs, which often approached the future of work through idealized visions and fantasies about managing and optimizing workplaces and workers. Reframing power relations as just "relationships" epitomized the tension around workers and employers, particularly regarding the asymmetries in who bears what responsibility for preparing for the future of work and under what terms.

Considering the work futures that the conferences and MOOCs explored and imagined, both contained spaces for expertise performance. These performances helped legitimize emergent vocabularies for the economy, especially how work will be organized and valued in new ways (Massey, 2013). Workers were often framed as needing to engage in flexible hybrid work, to develop and maintain core emotional skills and resiliency, and to skillfully use new AI technologies. These framings represented overlapping visions of the ideal future worker. Conferences and MOOCs created moments for the future of work's discursive labour politics to be consumed and legitimized (Anant and Coe, 2021). Competing narratives and imaginaries reflect differing interests' societal actors and are worth following as they give shape to new work geographies (Dries et al., 2024). The discourse I witnessed relied on productivity valorization and continuing established trends of pushing workers to be entrepreneurial subjects in the face of uncertain economic change (Cockayne, 2016; Kiely, 2024). However, imaginaries of self-improvement risk contributing to burnout, as workers face time constraints for learning and critical thinking while being pressured to demonstrate rapid upskilling (Hallin et al., 2025). Likewise, digital skills policy often exists at a macro level that does not account for the vastly different ways digital labour takes place across space and time (Richardson and Bissell, 2019).

The future is overdetermined and inherently uncertain. Futurity, in this context, refers to the multiplicity and plurality of possible co-existing futures—emphasizing what it means to be *a future*, not *the*

(singular) future. I have outlined a specific space–time configuration of future of work imaginaries. By discursively framing future of work issues around ideal worker subjects and their responses to change, the conferences and MOOCs were "performing the futurity" of work (Kinsley, 2010, p. 2776). The performances of expertise, either by conference presenters or the content of MOOCs used both new and familiar vocabularies and representations, adding specific detail to the future of work. Following (Pink, 2022), my qualitative analysis positions futures as "experiential"; futures are "continuously emerging" through everyday life and practices rather than as discrete, measurable, and calculable horizons. The future was, at times, presented as the latter, thus representing a fundamental tension in various future ontologies presented. Despite some diversity in the future of work imaginaries encountered, the responsibility for responding and adapting to the future of work was largely placed on workers, rather than employers, governments, or other institutions. This will be an important thread to follow, particularly considering that the future of work is framed across space and time, and I do so below.

In the discourses observed, the ideal worker was almost exclusively defined as highly skilled and flexible knowledge workers – to the exclusion of whole worker groups who are not higher status or white-collar workers in knowledge-based economies of the Global North (McDowell, 2017). More empirical work is needed to trace the contours of the future of work discourse and its impacts on specific labour geographies – especially to account for how care and social reproduction, for instance, are integral to value production beyond typical registers of the workplace (Winders and Smith, 2019). As Lehdonvirta et al. (2023) note, unpaid domestic work is still largely outside of research that estimates automation or AI impacts. For instance, an HR manager on a panel discussing wellbeing argued that understanding an employee's "work context is not enough, we need to understand them as a whole life context" – a disturbing prospect for many whose daily life is already largely "at work". Social reproduction has not been entirely absent from future of work discourse, albeit it emerged in a largely contradictory way that enrolled it under capitalist logics – promoting wellbeing or work-life balance to enhance productivity (Bakker and Gill, 2019). More could be done to explore how the future of work and new appearances or fantasies of work-life in geographically specific contexts are made to align with capital (Cowan, 2021). The future of work discourse and imaginaries, as observed, reveal an unstable framing that opens possibilities for thinking about specific work-life realities in contrast to expert or elite framings.

Overall, given unequal labour exchange – where production in all sectors takes place predominantly in the Global South while value is largely captured in the Global North (Hickel et al., 2024) – future of work research should explore geopolitical aspects beyond the Global North. As I argued above, the future of work discourse is not limited to technology but by a myriad of framings about skills workers will be expected to adopt in response to shifting currents of capital. Ultimately, I contend that academic researchers, policy makers, and industry should continue to carefully consider the power of imaginaries in shaping orientations toward the future of work. Likewise, the future of work has specific spatial contexts that need accounting for to better understand the uncertain, unpredictable, and uneven outcomes of workplace change and who will be most affected by change. By thinking through the futurity of work, we can position working life as open to change while recognizing that it is characterized by powerful social relations and institutions that have an interest in presenting it as a bounded phenomenon with predictable outcomes. If the future is radically open but can only be influenced under constrained social relations, both past and present knowledges are useful inflection points for determining the kind of future we want. Massey (2005) described the making of spaces and places as "temporary cohesions of articulations of relations, the provisional and partial enclosures, the repeated practices which chisel their way into being established flows" (p. 175). In this sense, the futurity of work can be seen as an imagining and articulating of futures and the relationships that will structure them, and as the ways power dynamics privilege certain futures over others.

4.5. *Strengths, limitations, and suggestions for future research*

A key strength of this study lies in the depth and richness of the qualitative data, which enabled a less conventional analytical approach to the future of work and labour geographies. This work also responds to calls for economic and labour geographers to consider futures and their discursive construction (Anant and Coe, 2021; Gong, 2024). Event ethnographies remain a relatively novel methodological approach for geographers (Koch, 2023). This study evaluated this method within a specific empirical context and its relevance to the subfields of labour and economic geography. While short-term events offer practical and interesting opportunities to consider relations, discourse, and imaginaries, they are not a substitute for other qualitative methods but rather "surprising and powerful entry points for research" (Koch, 2023, p. 9) which I deployed here as another way for geographers to engage with futures and the future of work specifically.

An importation limitation, particularly regarding the conferences, is the relatively high cost of attendance. Expensive events curated for businesses or individuals with discretionary budgets may pose a limiting factor for researchers, depending on their own research funding capacities. Likewise, as discussed in the previous section, the conferences were exclusively in North America, limiting analyses of broader geographical contexts of the future of work. Although the conferences and MOOCs were compelling discursive spaces, this study does not explicitly assess how these events influenced decisions made by workers or organizations beyond the event context. This opens opportunities for further triangulation of methods to seek out if and how such future of work discourses impact workplaces or other institutional settings. However, these events are interesting objects of study because they are institutional mediums for conveying expertise and imaginaries.

Future research could build on this work by examining how firms, workers, and community members define, interpret, and experience the "future of work," and by identifying discursive patterns across contexts and actors—not just business elites, academics, policymakers, grey literature, or popular media. Additionally, across the conferences and MOOCs, social reproduction and care work, while not entirely absent, was less clearly expressed. Future research might interrogate future of work imaginaries from the perspective of youth, students, seniors, unemployed individuals, or other groups outside of white-collar workers. Overall, how capitalism is persistent in reproducing social difference along different axes continues to be an important topic for economic and labour geographers (Werner et al., 2017). Future research could continue to theorize how social difference and the future of work is constructed in specific places and at different scales, particularly as futures are contested or envisioned outside of the Global North or in relation to alternative economic imaginaries and how these futures are resisted by marginalized communities (Bledsoe et al., 2022; Ouma et al., 2020).

Overall, the future of work continues to be broad in scope (Lynn et al., 2023; MacLeavy and Pitts, 2024). Geographers should continue to develop research that situates the spatiality of the future of work. Likewise, researchers can consider how to actively engage in shaping the future of work, presenting alternative imaginaries amid the array of social, political, and economic struggles over the future of work.

5. Conclusion

Earlier in the paper, I noted that geographers and other social scientists are beginning to pay attention to the future of work as an analytical category. Competing and complimentary narratives shape our understanding of the challenges surrounding work, its evolving meanings, and the role of technological change in society. How these narratives are constructed by different actors, including those outside of

academic research, are important for policy making and labour research. This article is a contribution to future of work literature in geography that takes seriously the activities and moments that define and create future of work imaginaries. Specifically, I employed event ethnography as a novel methodological lens to explore how future of work discourses and imaginaries were constructed through performances.

To this end, I have looked closely at the future of work rhetoric, imaginaries, and representations of knowledge production spaces. In contrast to research that critically analyses the discursive construction of technology in the future of work, I emphasized the discursive framing of workers therein. The analysis revealed that future of work narratives often place the burden of adaptation to technological and workplace changes on individual workers rather than on institutions, employers, or governments. Across these contexts representations of the 'ideal worker' emphasized that workers need to manage evolving flexibility between home and office environments, develop core emotional skills, and build proficiency in new technologies such as AI. This situation has the potential to further exacerbate precarity for workers as the future of work is imagined and enacted in ways that do not address social differences. The analysis here demonstrates the complexity of how technology is framed in the future of work discourse. Although technology was present, it became clear that across the conferences and MOOCs there was a focus on other social and cultural elements of workplaces as key aspects of future change, in addition to claims about the potential of technologies such as AI or automation.

While the future of work continues to be driven by technological concerns, geographers can continue to pursue broad theoretical frameworks of agency, work, and social reproduction to expand work-life politics and future of work geographies. Likewise, geographic scholarship on social reproduction is useful for examining how production and social reproduction intersect—or fail to intersect—with future of work theorizing. These directions can help geographers explore the futurity of work and the possibilities for worker agency. Geographers are well suited to examine the geopolitics of the future of work, identify who holds decision-making power and the dynamics shaping its articulation, and in analyzing what is at stake and who is responsible for preparing for and adapting to an uncertain future of work.

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Tyler Blackman: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization.

Declaration of Competing Interest

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